

The Disciple Whom Jesus Loved

Anonymity as structure, read across four scriptural corpora

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The Beloved Disciple of the Fourth Gospel has been pursued for eighteen centuries as a concealment problem, on the assumption that a name was known and withheld and that the task is recovery. This study argues that the Gospel does not withhold a name but specifies a position, tightly enough that the specification can be written out as nine conditions, each anchored in a locus, and that an assignment satisfying all nine at once is exhibited while every candidate the Gospel itself names elsewhere fails at one and the same condition. That result is established from inside the Fourth Gospel alone, and this study then opens the frame to the literature the Gospel inherits and to a fourth corpus that treats the same problem independently. Three findings follow. The attendant who inherits by seeing is a settled Hebrew Bible type, and 2 Kings 2:10 makes sight the explicit condition of succession, which is the structure John 19:35 assumes without arguing for it. The withheld name is a marked convention rather than an accident, and in Genesis 32:29 and Judges 13:17-18 it attaches precisely to the figure who stands in two registers, while Tobit 12:15 shows the convention's alternative resolution and so establishes its bivalence. And the Qur'ān supplies both a series of structurally identical unnamed servants and, at 18:22, an explicit instruction that withheld identifiers are not to be reconstructed, which is the hermeneutical rule the Johannine case exemplifies without stating. Against this the sharpest comparative result is a divergence rather than an echo: John grounds its warrant in autopsy and therefore must create a seeing position, while the Qur'ān repeatedly denies eyewitness access at 3:44, 11:49, 28:44-46 and 12:102 and grounds the report in the sending itself, and therefore creates no vacancy at all. Two corpora withhold names; only one is thereby obliged to specify a place. The structural claim seals. The identity of the occupant does not, and the paper says which of the two it closes.

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1. The designation, the thesis, and the change of scope

The Fourth Gospel names a figure five times by a relative clause and never by a name: *ho mathētēs hon ēgapa ho Iēsous* at 13:23, 19:26, 21:7 and 21:20, and *hon ephilei ho Iēsous* at 20:2. Bare chapter-and-verse references throughout are to the Fourth Gospel; every other citation names its book, and the appendix qualifies all of them so its tables stand alone. It designates the same figure without the epithet at 18:15-16, as the other disciple known to the high priest, and at 19:35, as the one who saw and has testified. It closes by asserting that this figure both testified and wrote, and by placing a corporate voice behind the assertion: *we* know that his testimony is true (21:24).

Eighteen centuries have treated this as concealment. A name is presumed to have existed and to have been suppressed, and the scholarly task is recovery; every reconstruction is an argument that some particular name was the one suppressed, and the list now runs from John son of Zebedee through Lazarus, Thomas, Mary Magdalene, John Mark and Paul to a range of readings under which no name was suppressed because no person was there.

The thesis is that the concealment frame is wrong. The Gospel specifies a position rather than withholding a name, and the position is specified tightly enough to be written out as a set of conditions any occupant must meet. Three results follow. An assignment satisfying all nine at once is exhibited at section 8, so the figure is not an incoherence produced by redaction. Every candidate the Gospel itself names elsewhere fails at the same single condition, so those failures are one structural fact seen from several angles rather than a set of

independent objections. And the condition they all fail is the anonymity itself, which is load-bearing rather than residual: a name written into the designation converts a positional figure into a second person, and the moment there are two persons the transposition of *kolpos* from 1:18 to 13:23 collapses from inheritance into proximity.

The change of scope, and what it costs

The requirement analysis above is established from inside the Fourth Gospel alone, and a study that stopped there would hold every other corpus to a strict comparative budget. This study holds no corpus to that budget, deliberately, because a claim about how withheld identity functions in scripture cannot be tested inside one book. Widening the frame changes the genre: this is no longer a Johannine paper with comparative furniture but a comparative paper with a Johannine anchor, and the shift has a real methodological price that is stated here rather than absorbed.

The price is that comparative work degrades into resemblance-collecting unless it is disciplined, and three rules hold it. First, **a parallel earns its place by what it separates, never by what it echoes**; an agreement gets a sentence of context and a divergence at the joint under examination gets the analysis. Second, **regular correspondence is required for any philological claim**, and a resemblance needing an ad hoc exception is reported as a resemblance. Third, **nothing here derives any text from any other**, in either direction; where a shared structure is carried by unrelated vocabulary, that is a stronger result than borrowing would be, because borrowing cannot explain it.

The corpora are four. The Hebrew Bible supplies the antecedent type of the attendant who inherits, and it is the literature the Fourth Gospel is written out of. The Qumran library and the pseudepigrapha supply the Second Temple setting in which unnamed designation and two-register counterparts were live conventions rather than curiosities. The Qur'an enters not as a late echo but as an independent treatment of the same problem, and it earns its place twice over: it carries a series of structurally identical unnamed servants, and it is the only one of the four to state a hermeneutical rule about withheld identifiers in its own voice.

2. The literature

The field is unusually well surveyed, unusually static, and unusually partitioned. The partition is the first finding: Johannine authorship scholarship, Qumran-Johannine scholarship, and Second Temple counterpart scholarship have all been productive and have barely spoken to one another on this question.

The patristic register and its quantitative thinness

Two external witnesses carry the tradition. Irenaeus, about 180, states that John, the disciple of the Lord, the one who leaned on his breast, published a Gospel at Ephesus.¹ Polycrates of Ephesus, about 190, names among the luminaries of Asia a John who reclined on the Lord's bosom, who was a priest wearing the *petalon*, and who was a witness and a teacher.² The Muratorian fragment adds a composition legend and a revelation to Andrew.³

Two features are habitually passed over. Both witnesses identify their John by the reclining scene rather than by parentage, and neither, at the point of identification, says son of Zebedee: Irenaeus writes *discipulus Domini*, and Polycrates describes a man with the high priestly frontlet, which is not a Galilean fisherman's description. And the identification arrives exactly when the Fourth Gospel had become the preferred text of the Valentinians, Heracleon having written the first known commentary on it, so an apostolic pedigree was worth what it cost. The tradition is doing polemical work at the moment it speaks, which is when an attribution most needs corroboration and least receives it. Against it stands Papias as Eusebius reports him, whose list names John twice, once among the apostles and once among Aristion and the elder John, disciples who *say* in the present tense, from which Eusebius infers two Johns and two Ephesian tombs.⁴ Eusebius had a motive, since a second John relieved him of a chiliast apostle; but the ambiguity is in Papias, and it is the earliest thing in the record.

The critical register

Once the Gospel was read as a redacted composition, the epithet became a datum about the text's formation and chapter 21 became the hinge. Bultmann read the figure as a construct standing for Gentile Christianity over against Peter;⁵ Kragerud as the representative of an itinerant prophetic circle;⁶ Kügler produced the most thorough symbolic treatment, a literary integrator with no historical residue;⁷ Thyen, from a different method, an intertextual construction referring the reader to the beloved figures of Israel's scriptures.⁸ The symbolic school is strongest where the historical school is weakest, on 13:23 and 20:8, and weakest where the text is most mundane, at 20:4 and 21:23.

Confessional scholarship, whose direction is the finding

Schnackenburg defended the apostolic identification in his first volume and retracted it by his third, settling on a Jerusalem disciple outside the Twelve.⁹ Brown moved over a longer arc from the son of Zebedee to an unknown minor figure and finally to a real witness carried in an idealised frame.¹⁰ That two of the century's most careful commentators moved in the same direction, away from the traditional name, under no external pressure to do so, is a datum about the internal evidence.

Western critical scholarship, disagreements named

Hengel argued the Ephesian tradition preserves the elder John, a Jerusalem disciple and head of a school, neither apostle nor fiction.¹¹ Bauckham radicalised it: the elder John is the Beloved Disciple, the *we* of 21:24 an authorial plural, the Gospel framed by an inclusio of eyewitness testimony from 1:35-40 to 21:24.^{12,13} Lincoln argues the eyewitness language is a function of the Gospel's trial motif, a rhetorical construction of witness rather than a historical claim about a source.¹⁴ Culpepper's study of the legend traces how the apostle acquired his biography and shows how little is early.¹⁵ The named-alternative proposals have never converged: Lazarus from Filson and Sanders through Eller, Witherington and Baltz;¹⁶⁻²⁰ John Mark from

Parker;²¹ Thomas from Charlesworth;²² Mary Magdalene from Jusino.²³

The Qumran register, and the partition

Brown's early studies and Charlesworth's later volumes established that the Fourth Gospel's dualistic vocabulary has its closest Semitic antecedent in the Two Spirits treatise of the Community Rule, where the spirit of truth and the spirit of deceit stand opposed under a Prince of Lights.^{24,25} That result is now standard and has decisively shaped how the Johannine *pneuma tēs alētheias* is read. What the surveyed work does not apply it to is the Beloved Disciple, and the omission is striking, because the same library supplies a founder figure designated by function and never by personal name, whose interpretation the community held as authoritative and to whom mysteries were disclosed that the prophets themselves had not been given.²⁶ The Teacher of Righteousness has been compared with the Johannine Jesus, and with the Paraclete, and with the community's own hermeneutic; he has not been set beside the Gospel's unnamed witness, which is where the formal analogy actually lies.

The counterpart register

A separate and well-developed literature concerns Second Temple figures who exist in two registers at once. Segal's work on the two-powers controversy, Fossum on the angel who bears the divine Name, and Gieschen on angelomorphic christology map a body of material in which a heavenly counterpart is neither a second god nor a stage a man enters after death.²⁷⁻²⁹ Rowland and, earlier, Odeberg connected John 1:51 to the targumic reading of Genesis 28:12, in which the angels ascend to behold Ya'qūb engraved on the throne and descend to behold him sleeping.^{30,31} In the works surveyed here this literature is brought to bear on Johannine christology and not on Johannine discipleship.

The Islamic exegetical register

The Qur'ānic corpus carries a series of figures designated by function and never named, and its own exegetical tradition has supplied names for nearly all of them: al-Khiḍr for the servant of 18:65, Yūsha' ibn Nūn for the young companion of 18:60, Āṣif ibn Barkhiyā for the one with knowledge of the Book at 27:40, Ḥabīb al-Najjār for the man of 36:20. The Western study of this material has concentrated on the origins of the Khiḍr figure and on its folkloric parallels. What the surveyed work does not draw from it is what it is best positioned to supply: a controlled case in which a scriptural text withholds an identifier, the withholding is documented, and the subsequent supply of a name by tradition is datable and observable from outside. That is precisely the process every Beloved Disciple reconstruction posits for the Johannine case and none can observe.

What the literature has not asked

Every position in the Johannine field, symbolic and historical alike, treats anonymity as a datum requiring a motive: modesty, redaction, community practice, idealisation, suppression. No work in the literature surveyed here asks whether the anonymity does work in the Gospel's own architecture, such that a name would break something rather than merely reveal something. The survey is by citation and not

systematic, so the negative claims in this section are claims about the surveyed literature and not about the field entire, and a single counter-instance would retire any of them. And the surveyed literature does not put the comparative form of the question, which is answerable: is withheld identity in this literature an accident of transmission or a marked convention, and if it is a convention, what does it attach to. Sections 5 through 7 answer the second question from three corpora, and section 8 answers the first.

3. The lexical excavation

Four languages, and the object is a designation rather than a term, so the excavation runs on the vocabulary the designation is built from in each corpus.

Greek: the two verbs, and what their alternation does not show

The epithet uses *agapaō* four times and *phileō* once, at 20:2. The homiletic distinction descending from Trench, with *agapaō* higher and *phileō* warmer or lesser, is refuted internally. The Father loves the Son with *agapaō* at 3:35 and with *phileō* at 5:20, the same relation carried by both verbs within two chapters. The disciple takes both. Lazarus takes both: *phileis* at 11:3, *ēgapa* at 11:5, *ephilei* at 11:36. The alternation at 21:15-17 sits inside a passage where *boskō* and *poimainō* and *arnia* and *probata* alternate on the same principle, which is Johannine stylistic variation. Two parties lose by this: the devotional reading of the epithet, and the objection that Lazarus is disqualified by the wrong love-verbs. The verbs are the same and the distribution is the same.

Greek: the adjective the Gospel does not use

The Synoptic title at the baptism and transfiguration is adjectival, *ho buios mou ho agapētos*, at Mark 1:11 and 9:7 with parallels, and Mark 12:6 applies it to the son in the vineyard. That adjective does not carry the title anywhere in the Fourth Gospel, which uses *monogenēs* instead, at 1:14, 1:18, 3:16 and 3:18. The two are one semantic field entered from two sides, since the Septuagint renders Hebrew *yahid*, only, by *agapētos* at Genesis 22:2, 22:12 and 22:16. The observation is exact and limited: in the Gospel where the christological *agapētos* is absent, the participial love-clause *hon ēgapa* is attached to a disciple. The title is not shared; it is relocated downward.

The Ascension of Isaiah is worth setting beside this, because there *the Beloved*, *ho ēgapēmenos*, is a standing christological title used throughout as a proper designation.³² That a Jewish-Christian apocalypse of roughly the Fourth Gospel's period can run the participial form as a title for the Son sharpens the Johannine choice: the same formation was available at the higher register and this Gospel puts it at the lower one.

Greek: kolpos, with an honest disjunction

The Prologue places the only Son *eis ton kolpon tou patros* (1:18) and says he *exēgēsato*, set forth, the God no one has seen. The supper places the disciple *en tō kolpō tou Iēsou* (13:23). Same noun, one step down the transmission chain.

Two disjunctions are stated rather than smoothed. The prepositions differ, *eis* against *en*; Koine often uses *eis* where *en* is expected and many commentators treat them as equivalent here, while others read a genuine directional. The matter is disputed and is not resolved here. And 13:23 is not the only somatic term in the scene: at 13:25 and again at 21:20 the disciple leans back *epi to stēthos autou*, on his chest, a different noun, so the *kolpos* link to the Prologue is carried by 13:23 alone.

The Syriac reception is worth one line, because it is the earliest Semitic-language reading of the pair and it saw the transposition: the Peshitta renders both with *‘ubbā*, bosom, at 1:18 and 13:23, keeping the two loci lexically joined.

Hebrew: the attendant's vocabulary

The type examined in section 5 has a fixed vocabulary and it is worth having before the texts. *Mesaret*, from *ṣ-r-t*, is the attendant or minister, used of Yehoshu‘a at Exodus 24:13 and 33:11 and of Elisha at 1 Kings 19:21; it denotes service in proximity rather than servitude, and it is the word used of priestly service before the presence. *Na‘ar*, young man, is used of Yehoshu‘a at Exodus 33:11 and carries the sense of a subordinate in attendance. *Pi shnayim*, the double portion Elisha requests at 2 Kings 2:9, is not a request for twice the power but the technical share of the firstborn under Deuteronomy 21:17, so the disciple is asking to inherit as a son inherits, which is the exact register in which John 19:27 transfers a household.

Hebrew: the withheld name, and the bivalence check

Two verbs govern the withholding. At Genesis 32:30 the wrestler answers Ya‘qūb with a question, *lammah zeb tish‘al li-shmi*, why is it that you ask my name, and blesses him without answering. At Judges 13:18 the messenger answers Manoah with the same refusal and a reason: *lammah zeb tish‘al li-shmi we-bu’ peli’y*, why do you ask my name, seeing it is *peli’y*, wonderful or beyond reach, from *ṣp-l-ʔ*, the root of that which is too high to be grasped. The refusal is not reticence; it is given a stated ground, and the ground is that the name belongs to a register the asker does not occupy.

Running the bivalence check on the convention returns a genuine split, and the split matters. Withheld identity in this literature resolves two opposite ways. It is withheld and then disclosed, as at Tobit 12:15 where Raphael, who has travelled the whole narrative as Azariah son of Ananias, names himself at the end; and it is withheld and refused, as at Genesis 32:30 and Judges 13:18. Both are conventional and neither is a defect of the text. The Fourth Gospel belongs to the second branch, and belonging to a branch is the beginning of the argument rather than its end, since a convention establishes that a name may be withheld and does not establish why this one must be.

Arabic: the designation vocabulary of the unnamed servant

The Qur’anic figures of section 7 are designated by four devices, and the devices are the point. By relation to God: *‘abdan min ‘ibādīnā*, a servant from among Our servants (18:65). By relation to a named figure: *fatāhu*, his young companion (18:60-62), and *ṣāḥibihī*, his companion (9:40). By position in a pair: *thāniya thnayni*, the second of two (9:40). And by possession of a quality: *alladhī ‘indahu ‘ilmun*

min al-kitāb, the one with whom was knowledge from the Book (27:40); *raḥulun mu‘minun min āli fir‘awna yaktumu imānahu*, a believing man of Pharaoh's house who concealed his faith (40:28). Not one of these is a name, and every one of them is a position.

The cognate field, and a negative that is a finding

Mathētēs is unremarkable and the love-verbs are ordinary Greek. *Kolpos* has a usage counterpart in Hebrew *ḥēq*, bosom or lap, used of intimacy and of the nursing child, but there is no assertible loan relation and none is claimed; the correspondence is of usage rather than of form. The single philologically load-bearing item in the vicinity is a translation equivalence rather than an etymology, the Septuagint's *agapētos* for *yaḥīd*.

That is a negative and it is the section's strongest finding. The designation carries no lexical import from anywhere. Every term in it is native Johannine Greek, so the epithet cannot be explained as a title borrowed from another tradition in Greek dress. And the same holds across the comparison: the Hebrew type runs on *ṣ-r-t* and *ṣy-r-š*, the Qumran designation on *moreh*, the Qur’anic on *‘abd* and *fatā* and *ṣāḥib*, and the Johannine on a relative clause with *agapāō*. Four corpora make the same structural move with four unrelated vocabularies. A shared structure carried by unrelated words cannot be explained by borrowing, which is why the comparison in the sections that follow is doing structural work and not genealogical work.

4. The Johannine base

Each locus read for what it says before it is read for what the reconstructions built on it say.

1:35-40. Two disciples of the Baptist follow; one is named Andrew at 1:40 and the other is not named at all. The passage carries the abiding question, *pou meneis*, and its answer. It does not carry the epithet, and treating it as the figure's first appearance is an inference resting on the anonymity and on the framing device Bauckham proposes. Stated as evidence it manufactures an inclusio and reads the inclusio back as proof, which is circular.

13:23-26. The disciple is introduced with the epithet, reclining in the bosom of Jesus (AS), and Peter signals to him to ask who the betrayer is. Two things separate from the devotional reading. It is a channel scene: Peter cannot ask and routes his question through the figure, the first appearance of a pattern in which the figure mediates and never initiates. And the position is stated before any function is assigned to it, which is the reverse of how an honorific works.

18:15-16. The other disciple is *gnōstos tō archierei*, known to the high priest, with standing enough to bring Peter past the doorkeeper. This is a gratuitous social fact: it advances no theological point and is not required by the narrative, which is the kind of detail a symbolic construction has no reason to acquire. It also damages the Galilean identification, since Acts 4:13 calls Peter and John *agrammatōi kai idiōtai*, and the high priest's household is not where that description places a man.

19:25-27. The figure stands with the mother of Jesus (AS), Maryam, and receives her: *idou ho huīos sou*, and to the disciple *idou hē mētēr*

sou, and from that hour he took her *eis ta idia*. He is present where the narrative has the others absent. He acquires a household obligation, which presupposes a household and coheres with 18:15 and with nothing in the Galilean profile. And the transfer runs downward, from the departing Son to the remaining disciple, which is the direction every locus in this dossier runs.

19:35. *Kai ho beōrakōs memartyrēken, kai alēthinē autou estin hē martyria.* The verse does not name the seer and does not say he is the Beloved Disciple; the identification, though nearly universal, is an inference. What it does unambiguously is ground the Gospel's warrant in autopsy, which fixes seeing as a requirement and forecloses any candidate whose access is visionary rather than ocular.

20:2-10. The figure runs with Peter, arrives first, stoops and looks, waits, enters second, and *eiden kai episteusen*. He believes on the evidence of grave cloths and before any appearance, which is the strongest card the symbolic reading holds. He also loses a footprint and defers at the entrance, which is paradigmatic of nothing. The verse supplies the one *phileō* in the series and the explicit equation of the epithet with *ton allon mathētēn*.

21:7 and 21:20-24. The figure recognises the Lord from the boat and tells Peter; Peter asks about him and receives the conditional at 21:22; the narrator reports that the saying went out that this disciple would not die, and corrects it. The correction is the most important datum in the dossier and is regularly under-read. The narrator does not deny the abiding. He restates the conditional exactly and declines to affirm that the man will not die, which is what one writes when the saying is true at one level and the death is true at another. He then asserts that this disciple testifies and wrote these things, and adds *oidamen*.

The disjunction at 21:2. The boat list gives Simon Peter, Thomas called Didymos, Nathanael of Cana, the sons of Zebedee, and two others of his disciples. It is routinely cited as evidence that the figure appearing at 21:7 is a son of Zebedee. It supports the opposite at least as well: the sons of Zebedee are named, and two disciples are then left unnamed in a list that had no other reason to include them.

The rhetorical situation. None of these loci is a technical definition, and one of them, 21:23, is explicitly a correction of a misreading already circulating. What the loci give is a consistent positional description assembled incidentally across eight scenes, which is more durable evidence than a definition would be.

5. The antecedent type: the attendant who inherits by seeing

The Fourth Gospel did not invent the figure of a disciple who stands in attendance, receives by proximity, and carries the master's work forward after a departure. It is a settled Hebrew Bible type with a fixed vocabulary, a fixed sequence, and, in its clearest instance, an explicit condition of transfer.

Yehoshu'a and Mūsā: the attendant who does not leave the tent

Yehoshu'a is *mesbaret mosheb*, the attendant of Mūsā, at Exodus 24:13, and Exodus 33:11 gives the datum that matters: when Mūsā returned to the camp, his attendant Yehoshu'a, a *na'ar*, *lo' yamish mitokh ha'obel*, did not depart from within the tent. The master goes out and the attendant remains. Numbers 11:28 keeps him in the same relation, and the succession is formal: hands are laid on him and something of the master's *bod*, his splendour, is set upon him (Numbers 27:18-20), so that he is filled with a spirit of wisdom because those hands were laid (Deuteronomy 34:9).

Three elements of the Johannine profile are already present. Proximity is the qualification. Remaining is what the attendant does when the master does not. And the transfer runs downward at a departure, in a scene staged for it.

Elisha and Eliyāhū: sight as the stated condition

The clearest instance is 2 Kings 2 and it is the hinge of this section. Elisha has been *mesbaret* to Eliyāhū since 1 Kings 19:21. At the departure he asks for *pi shnayim be-ruhaka*, a double portion of your spirit, which is the firstborn's inheritance share under Deuteronomy 21:17 and therefore a request to inherit as a son. The answer is a condition, and the condition is ocular: *im tir'eh oti luqqah me'ittak yehi lekha ken*, if you see me as I am taken from you it shall be so for you, and if not, it shall not (2 Kings 2:10). The narrative then discharges the condition explicitly: *we-Elisha' ro'eh*, and Elisha was seeing, and he cries out, and then he saw him no more (2 Kings 2:12). The mantle falls and he takes it up.

This is the structure the Fourth Gospel assumes at 19:35 without arguing for it. Sight is not incidental to the transmission and is not merely evidential; it is the condition on which the inheritance is granted. When John spends its whole warrant on *ho beōrakōs memartyrēken*, it is operating a rule its own literature had already made explicit, and this is why the seeing condition in section 8 is not a modern imposition on the text.

The inversion at the other end is worth stating exactly. Eliyāhū does not die; he is taken. In the Fourth Gospel the departure belongs to the master and the not-dying rumour attaches to the disciple, and 21:23 has to correct it. The same pair of motifs appears in both places with the assignments exchanged, and the Johannine correction is precisely a refusal to let the master's motif migrate to the servant.

Bārūkh and Yirmiyāhū: the writing hand that is not the voice

Jeremiah 36 supplies the other half. Bārūkh ben Neriah writes at the prophet's dictation *'al pi Yirmiyāhū* (36:4, and again at 36:18, where he says the prophet spoke and he wrote with ink), and Jeremiah 45 gives him a short oracle addressed to him alone. The structure is a prophetic word with a distinct scribal hand behind its written form, the two named separately in the text itself.

This is the exact shape of John 21:24, where a testifying figure and a corroborating voice are distinguished in one sentence, and it

establishes that the arrangement was ordinary rather than an embarrassment requiring explanation. It also supplies the mechanism by which a name attaches to a corpus: Bārūkh became the ascribed author of an entire literature, 1 Baruch, 2 Baruch, 3 Baruch and the Paraleipomena, none of it his. A scribal name known from one book collects a library. That process is observable here and is exactly what the elder-John reconstruction posits for the Johannine case, where it is not observable.

Gehazi: the negative control

The type has a failure mode and the literature records it. Gehazi is Elisha's *na'ar*, in the same position, and at 2 Kings 5:20-27 he uses the proximity for private gain and inherits the leprosy instead of the mantle. The control matters because it shows the type is a real structure with conditions and not a narrative habit: proximity alone confers nothing, and what is transmitted is transmitted on terms.

What the type does not supply

One Johannine feature is absent from every instance and a second is undetermined. Absent: none of these attendants is anonymous, all four being named repeatedly, and that is a fact about the texts rather than an inference. Undetermined: whether any of them stands in two positions at once is not settled here, and it cannot be settled by their being named, since section 6 shows that being named is no evidence that a figure does not stand in two positions. The ascent at 2 Kings 2:11-12 is the case that would have to be examined, since a departing figure taken up while his successor is required to watch is at least a candidate, and this study does not examine it. The type therefore accounts for the transmission and the seeing, does not account for the anonymity, and leaves the co-presence open rather than excluded. Sections 6 and 7 are required for the anonymity, and section 6 for the co-presence the earlier material leaves undecided. Stating this is the point: a comparison that explained everything would be a derivation, and this one explains part.

6. The counterpart: one figure, two registers

The second element has a different provenance. It is not the attendant type but a body of Second Temple material in which a figure is simultaneously present on earth and in a heavenly register, with neither location being the real one behind the other.

The angel who carries the Name

The base of this material is the Hebrew Bible's *mal'akh YHWH*, who both is and is not the one who sends him. He speaks in the first person as God at Genesis 16:13 and 31:11-13; he is addressed as God at Genesis 32:30; and Exodus 23:20-21 states the mechanism, *ki sbemi be-qirbo*, for my Name is within him, which is why he must be obeyed and will not pardon transgression. This is not a second deity, and the texts are careful in exactly the way they must be. It is one identity present in two registers, and the Name is what links them.

Bethel, and the pronoun

The Fourth Gospel supplies its own antecedent in its first chapter. At 1:51 the angels of God ascend and descend *epi ton huion tou anthrōpou*, upon the Son of Man. The base text is Genesis 28:12,

where the Septuagint has them ascending and descending *ep' autēs*, feminine, on the ladder, and the Hebrew *bo* is ambiguous between on it and on him. John resolves the ambiguity toward the person, which is the direction the targumic tradition also resolves it: Targum Neofiti and Pseudo-Jonathan have the angels ascend to behold the image of Yāqūb engraved on the throne of glory and descend to behold him sleeping, and Genesis Rabbah carries the same shuttle.^{30,31}

The traffic exists because both are present at once. The heavenly counterpart is not a state entered after death and not a figure the sleeper will become; he is on the throne while the man lies on the stone.

What the parallel separates. Genesis localises access: the traffic runs between heaven and a place, and the place receives a name, house of God and gate of heaven. John relocates access to a person, and the pronoun is the whole of the move. That is the same operation the Gospel performs on the temple at 2:19-21 and on the rival mountains at 4:21-23, which identifies the counterpart tradition as material this author is handling rather than material he happens to resemble.

The pseudepigraphic instances

Three texts show the structure was ordinary in this period rather than exotic.

The Prayer of Joseph, which survives because Origen quoted it while commenting on this very Gospel, has Yāqūb speak in the first person as an angel of God and a ruling spirit who had descended to earth and tabernacled among men, using a verb cognate to the *eskēnōsen* of John 1:14.³³

1 Enoch 71 is the sharpest instance in the corpus. The seer, having spent the Similitudes beholding a heavenly Son of Man, is finally told *you are the Son of Man who is born to righteousness*. The visionary discovers that the figure he has been observing is himself in the other register. Whatever one concludes about the passage's relation to the rest of the Similitudes, and its integration is debated, the conception it states is unambiguous: a man on earth and a figure on the throne can be one identity, and the man can be unaware of it.³⁵

2 Enoch 22 supplies the robing: the seer's earthly garments are removed, he is anointed and clothed in the garments of glory, and he becomes like one of the glorious ones.³⁵ The Ascension of Isaiah runs the same imagery in reverse, with robes stored in the seventh heaven awaiting the righteous who are still on earth.³²

The Qumran instances

The Qumran library supplies two of the strongest. 11QMelchizedek presents Melchizedek as a heavenly deliverer occupying the *elohim* of Psalm 82, a figure with a name from Genesis operating in a register the Genesis narrative does not describe. And the Self-Glorification Hymn, preserved in 4Q491 and related material, has a speaker claim a throne among the *elim* and ask who is like him among the angels, while remaining a teacher among men. The identity of that speaker is genuinely disputed, with readings ranging from Michael to a human teacher of the community, and the dispute is reported here rather

than resolved; what is not disputed is that the text stages a single voice speaking from both registers at once.³⁴

And two Second Temple attestations from outside the visionary literature

Matthew 18:10 has the little ones' angels continually beholding the Father's face while the children stand on earth. Acts 12:15 has a household conclude, of a man they believe imprisoned, that the figure at the door is *his angel*, which requires that a living man's counterpart be independently locatable and mistakable for him. Neither is apocalyptic and both assume the doctrine as ordinary furniture.

What this supplies and what it does not

The counterpart material supplies the co-presence the attendant type does not establish, and it supplies the two places at which the two predicates are severally true, which is not a mechanism transmitting anything between them: the abiding is predicated at one place and the death at the other, and no inference runs from either to the other. What the rumour at 21:23 gets wrong is not a failed inference but a misassignment, a predicate asserted at the place it does not hold. It does not supply the transmission structure, which section 5 supplied, and it does not by itself supply the anonymity, which section 7 addresses. Three elements and a fourth beside them, with two provenances settled and one open: the transmission belongs to the attendant type, the withheld name to the refusal convention, and the co-presence is exhibited plainly in the Second Temple material and left undetermined in the earlier. The three are individually necessary and jointly insufficient, and the corpus supplies its own proof: the Qumran founder of section 7 carries functional designation and historicity and leaves no vacancy behind him. The fourth thing is the autopsy warrant of section 7, which obliges a text grounded in sight to place a seer inside the sequence it narrates. The four are claimed jointly sufficient, no one of them carrying the foreclosure alone, and the claim is testable because its consequent asserts nothing its antecedent already contains: any text that grounds the warrant of its own narrated past in a witness's sight, stages a transmission from its central figure to that witness, designates him by position, and stands him in two registers, must withhold the name of that witness. The first three properties are individually compatible with a named witness, and section 5 exhibits one: Elisha satisfies all three and is named on every page. No single one of the four forecloses the name and the section's own examples prove it. Elisha satisfies the first three and is named on every page. Enoch at 1 Enoch 71, Yāqūb in the Prayer of Joseph, Melchizedek at 11QMelchizedek and the robed seer of 2 Enoch 22 each stand in two positions at once and are named throughout, so the fourth property is no more sufficient alone than the other three. What forecloses the name is the conjunction, and the reason is the one section 7 gives read against the whole set: a witness whose warrant is his own sight, whose transmission the text stages, whom it designates by position, and who is at the same time a counterpart rather than a second individual, has no name the designation could carry without dissolving the position it was built to hold. Inertness alone is shown for the fourth and for the first three taken together, and is asserted for the first and the second taken singly,

where no counterexample is worked here. The four together are not inert, which is what the conjunction claims and what the second falsifier at section 10 tests. A text carrying all four and specifying no such place refutes the claim, and no such text is known to this study.

7. The withheld name: convention, refusal, and a controlled case

The third element is the one the Johannine field has treated as a problem and the surrounding literature treats as a device. The question is whether withheld identity in scripture is an accident of transmission or a marked convention, and if a convention, what it attaches to.

Refusal, and its stated ground

Two Hebrew Bible scenes refuse a name outright and both give a reason. At Genesis 32:30 the wrestler answers Yāqūb with *lammah zeh tish'al li-shmi*, why is it that you ask my name, and blesses him without answering; the man then names the place instead. At Judges 13:18 the messenger answers Manoah with the identical formula and supplies the ground: *we-hu' peli'y*, seeing it is beyond reach.

The Fourth Gospel performs the same convention in its own first chapter, and performs it on a named man. Priests and Levites are sent from Jerusalem to ask the Baptist *su tis ei*, who are you, and the narrator frames the answer in a doubled formula, *hōmologēsēn kai ouk ērnēsato kai hōmologēsēn*, he confessed and did not deny but confessed, so that the refusal is staged as a confession rather than an evasion. Three titles are then declined in order, not the Christ, not Elijah, not the Prophet (1:20-21). Pressed for something to carry back to those who sent them, he answers with a function and not a name: *egō phōnē boōntos en tē erēmō*, I am a voice crying in the wilderness (1:23). Forty verses later two of his disciples follow, one named Andrew and one not named at all (1:35-40).

Two limits travel with this and both bind. The Baptist is named throughout, so what he declines are titles and not his name, and the parallel is to the marking of the refusal rather than to the withholding of a personal name. And nothing here identifies him with the figure of section 4: 5:35 speaks of him in the past tense and 3:30 has him decrease. What the passage establishes is narrower and is what section 7 needs. The staging of a refusal as a marked act, which Genesis 32:29 and Judges 13:18 supply from outside, is also performed inside the anchor corpus, before the epithet appears, by the figure out of whose circle the unnamed disciple walks, and it is the only instance of that staging this corpus supplies from itself. What it does not supply is an internal instance of a withheld personal name, and the section's governing claim rests where it did, on the two Hebrew Bible scenes and on Qumran. The passage corroborates and carries no claim.

Two features of these refusals matter. The refusal is marked, not passive: the text stages the question so that the withholding can be performed. And it attaches specifically to the figure who stands in two registers, which is the figure of section 6. The withheld name and the two-register position occur together, and they occur together because a counterpart is not a second individual with a second name.

Disclosure, and the bivalence

The Gospel also states in its own voice, twice and at both of its endings, that it withholds by choice. Many other signs were done which are not written in this book (20:30), and there are many other things which, were they written, the world could not contain (21:25). Neither passage concerns the disciple and neither is offered here as evidence that his name was among the withheld things. The omission of signs does not transfer to the omission of a name, and no inference is drawn here from the one to the other. What the two passages establish is that this text treats deliberate omission as an ordinary editorial act and says so twice where a reader cannot miss it, which bears on the prior a reader brings to any silence in it and settles nothing about this one. Like the passage above, this corroborates and carries no claim.

The convention resolves the other way as often. Tobit's companion travels the whole narrative as Azariah son of the great Ananias (5:13) and discloses himself at the end: *I am Raphael, one of the seven* (12:15). The Emmaus narrative at Luke 24:31 runs the same shape with recognition rather than announcement. Withheld-then-disclosed is as conventional as withheld-and-refused, and the Fourth Gospel belongs unmistakably to the second branch, since it withholds through twenty-one chapters and closes on 21:24 without disclosing.

This bivalence carries a real qualification against the paper's own thesis and it is stated here rather than in a footnote. If withholding is conventional, then it requires less special explanation, which cuts against calling the anonymity load-bearing. The two claims are compatible and the distinction is exact: **the convention establishes that a name may be withheld; it does not establish why this particular Gospel's architecture breaks if the name is supplied.** Convention supplies availability. Section 8 supplies necessity. Neither substitutes for the other.

Designation by function: the Teacher of Righteousness

The Qumran library supplies the closest formal analogue in the whole comparison and the surveyed literature does not use it in this debate. The community's founding figure is designated *moreh ha-tsedeq*, the Teacher of Righteousness, throughout the Damascus Document and the pesharim, and he is never given a personal name in any surviving text.²⁶ He is a real historical individual by every indication: he has a career, opponents designated the same way, the Wicked Priest and the Man of the Lie, and a body of interpretation the community holds as authoritative. The Habakkuk peshar states his qualification in terms that are worth setting beside John 21:24: God made known to him all the mysteries of the words of his servants the prophets.

The parallel is formal and tight. A community preserves a founder known only by a functional designation; the designation names his relation and his office rather than his person; the community's own writings assume the reader knows who is meant; and the personal name is unrecoverable from the corpus. Every element of the Johannine situation is present, including the corporate voice, and no proposal in the surveyed literature infers from that designation that the Teacher was a literary construct. The comparison does not prove

the Beloved Disciple historical. It removes the assumption that a functionally designated founder is anomalous, or that anonymity is evidence of fictionality, which is an assumption a great deal of the symbolic literature rests on.

The Qur'ānic series, and a controlled case

The Qur'ān designates by function and withholds the name systematically enough that the practice is a feature of its narrative style rather than an accident of any one passage.

The servant of 18:65 is *'abdan min 'ibādīnā ātaynāhu rahmatan min 'indinā wa-allamnāhu min ladunnā 'ilman*, a servant from among Our servants to whom We had given mercy from Us and taught knowledge from Our own presence. He is never named. The young companion who carries the fish at 18:60-62 is *fatāhu*, his young man, and is never named. The one who brings the throne at 27:40 is *alladhibi 'indahu 'ilmun min al-kitāb*. The man who runs from the far end of the city at 36:20 is *rajulun min aqsā l-madīnati yas'ā*. The believer in Pharaoh's house at 40:28 is *rajulun mu'minin min āli fir'awna yaktumu imānahu*, a man who concealed his faith, which is anonymity as a described state rather than a narrative device. And at 9:40 the companion in the cave is *thāniya thnayni*, the second of two, designated purely by position in a pair, in the same verse in which *sakina* descends.

What makes this a controlled case rather than one more parallel is that the subsequent history is observable. The exegetical tradition supplied names for nearly all of them: al-Khiḍr at 18:65, Yūsha' ibn Nūn at 18:60, Āṣif ibn Barkhiyā at 27:40, Ḥabīb al-Najjār at 36:20. The supply is datable, its channels are documented, and the text it attached to is unchanged and available for comparison. This is precisely the process every reconstruction posits for the Johannine case, where the text's earlier state cannot be inspected, and here it can be watched from outside. The observation to draw is narrow and firm: a scriptural corpus can withhold identifiers as a settled practice, and its interpretive tradition will reliably supply names anyway, and the supply tells us about the tradition rather than about the text.

The rule stated in a text's own voice

One further item has no parallel in the other three corpora and is the reason this section ends here. Discussing the sleepers of the cave and the disputes about their number, Q 18:22 states that people say three and a fourth was their dog, and five and a sixth was their dog, *rajman bi-l-ghayb*, guessing at the unseen, and instructs: say, my Lord knows best their number, and few know them; so do not dispute about them except with an evident argument, and do not ask any of them for a ruling about them.

This is a hermeneutical instruction about withheld detail, given in the text's own voice, and it says that a detail the revelation does not supply is not to be reconstructed and that reconstruction is guessing at what is hidden. The Fourth Gospel supplies an instance of the practice and no rule; the Qur'ān supplies the rule and applies it to a case of its own. Neither text depends on the other for this and no derivation is claimed. What the juxtaposition yields is that the principle this paper argues for the Johannine vacancy is not a modern methodological

preference imported into an ancient text. It is stated as a principle inside the comparative field.

The discriminating divergence, and it is the sharpest result here

The comparison also produces its most important separation, and a divergence at the joint is worth more than any of the echoes above.

The Fourth Gospel grounds its warrant in autopsy. *We beheld his glory* (1:14); the one who has seen has testified (19:35); this disciple testifies and wrote (21:24); what we have heard, what we have seen with our eyes, what we looked upon and our hands handled (1 John 1:1-3). Because the warrant is sight, the text requires someone who saw, and requiring someone who saw means specifying a place for him. **The vacancy is the cost of the autopsy warrant.**

The Qurʾān grounds the warrant of its narrated past in the sending rather than in a witness, and it says so by explicitly denying eyewitness access to those events. The scope of that claim is the narrated past and no further, and the limit is stated here because the corpus supplies its own counter-instance: Q 53:11-12 grounds a claim in the Prophet's own sight, *mā kadhaba l-fuʾādu mā raʾā*, the heart did not lie about what it saw, and 17:1 has the showing done to him directly. So the corpus is not without sight-grounded warrant; what it does not do is ground the prophetic narratives in a witness to them. You were not on the western side when We decreed the command to Mūsā, and you were not among the witnesses; you were not a dweller among the people of Madyan; you were not at the side of the mountain when We called (28:44-46). You were not with them when they cast their pens as to which of them should have charge of Maryam, nor were you with them when they disputed (3:44). This is of the tidings of the unseen which We reveal to you; you did not know it, neither you nor your people, before this (11:49). You were not with them when they agreed upon their plan (12:102).

Two corpora withhold names. Only one of them is thereby obliged to specify a position, and the difference is traceable to where each locates the warrant of its narrated past. The Fourth Gospel's narrated past is the very sequence its witness is said to have seen, so a witness to it must be placed inside it. The Qurʾān's narrated past lies centuries before its recipient, so no witness to it is available and none is claimed, which is what 28:44-46 states. The discrimination is between two relations of narrator to narrated and not between a corpus that values sight and one that does not. A text that grounds itself in sight must have a seer, and a seer must have a place, and the place is what the Fourth Gospel spends eight scenes constructing. A text that grounds itself in the sending needs no seer at all, and its unnamed servants are unnamed for a different reason, which 18:22 states. The parallel would be a coincidence if the two withholdings had the same cause; they do not, and the divergence is what makes the Johannine vacancy legible as a structure rather than a habit.

One further Qurʾānic case, read for its difference

The Mūsā narrative at 18:60-82 is the closest Qurʾānic analogue to the attendant type of section 5, and it inverts it at the decisive point. Mūsā asks to follow the servant, *bal attabiʾuka ʿalā an tuʿallimani mimma*

ʿullimta rushdā (18:66), and is told *innaka lan tastaṭīʿa maʿiya ṣabrā*, you will not be able to have patience with me (18:67). The condition of the companionship is that he ask nothing (18:70). He asks three times, and the relation is dissolved: *bādhā firāqu baynī wa-baynik*, this is the parting between me and you (18:78), after which the servant explains all three acts before departing.

Set against 2 Kings 2 the divergence is exact. Elisha meets the condition, sees, and inherits. Mūsā fails the condition, does not abide, and the relation ends, and the text closes the account with a full explanation rather than a residue. Set against the Fourth Gospel the divergence is the same and sharper: John's disciple abides, sees, and receives a household and a testimony, and the Gospel closes on an unresolved conditional at 21:22 rather than on an explanation. Three corpora stage a disciple's abiding as the condition of what is transmitted; the outcomes are inheritance, dissolution, and an open conditional, and the third of those is the one that leaves a vacancy behind it.

8. The structural reading

The problem the Gospel creates for itself

The Prologue makes two commitments that are hard to hold together. No one has ever seen God (1:18), and the Word became flesh and we beheld his glory, *etheasametha* (1:14). The unseen is expounded by the seen, and the verb at 1:18 is *exēgēsato*, which is not a metaphor for presence but a word for setting something forth so that it can be known.

This creates a defect at the departure. If the unseen Father is known only through the Son's exposition, and the Son departs, the exposition terminates. The Gospel is written after the temple has fallen and while the generation that saw is thinning, for readers who did not see, and 20:29 says so. The standard apocalyptic patch for a closed channel, a sealed vision delivered to a named ancient, is unavailable to this author, because the whole claim of the book is that this happened in a nameable place under a nameable prefect. What is needed is continuity of testimony without pseudonymity and without a new revelation.

The comparison of sections 5 through 7 shows the author had every component to hand. The Hebrew Bible supplied a transmission structure in which an attendant inherits at a departure on the condition that he sees. The Second Temple counterpart material exhibits plainly and without argument a figure who is one identity in two registers, which the Hebrew Bible material may or may not also carry, section 5 leaving that open. And the convention of the withheld name supplied a designation that is a position rather than a person, marked, and already attached in Genesis 32 and Judges 13 to precisely the two-register figure. What the Fourth Gospel does is assemble the three.

What the position must carry

The loci of section 4 specify the repair, and the specification can be written out. Nine conditions, each anchored, of which two collapse into one under the mechanism stated below, so the independent

count is eight and the ninth is the eighth read from its other side. Each is given with its antecedent named.

Two axes carry the word register in this paper and they are orthogonal. The transmission axis is a chain of positions, Father, Son, disciple, along which the exposition descends; the ontological axis is the pairing of one identity across heaven and earth. The disciple sits on both, and they meet only at the individual who occupies both: a position on one axis fixes nothing on the other, and the single point of contact is that one person stands at a place on each. The rumour at 21:23 is a predication error at exactly that point of contact, taking what is true of him on the ontological axis and asserting it of the body that stands on the transmission chain. Where the comparative sections speak of a settling register or a fidelity register the sense is lexical and belongs to neither axis. With that fixed, the occupant must have **seen**, per 19:35 and 1:14, which is the Elisha condition of 2 Kings 2:10. He must be **unnamed in this Gospel's own designation of him**, which the epithet enforces on all five occurrences, which Genesis 32:30 and Judges 13:18 establish as a marked device, and which a candidate the Gospel names in another scene cannot satisfy however well he fits elsewhere. He must be **co-present** rather than successive, per 13:23 against 16:7, which is the counterpart structure of section 6. He must **abide**, per 21:22-23 and 1:38-39, which is the *lo' yamish mittokh ha'ohel* of Exodus 33:11. He must be **Judean with standing in the high priestly household**, per 18:15-16. He must be **outside the Twelve**, since the Gospel assigns him no apostolic designation and barely uses the category. He must be **receiver-side**, taking at 13:23 and 19:27 rather than supplying. He must occupy the **inherited bosom**, the *kolpos* of 13:23 one step down the transmission chain from the *kolpos* of 1:18, which is the *pi shnayim* of 2 Kings 2:9 read as a son's share. And he must be **distinct from the final hand**, per 21:24, which is the Bārūkh arrangement of Jeremiah 36.

The first result is that these nine are jointly satisfiable, and the demonstration is an exhibited assignment rather than a pairwise check, since pairwise consistency would not establish joint satisfiability for a set of this size, so the assignment is exhibited, and it is exhibited as a stipulated profile carrying no candidate, because an assignment read off the surviving row of the screen would make the consistency proof and the screening result one object and neither could then support the other. Stipulate a man of Jerusalem, of a family with access to the high priestly household, not of the Twelve, present at the supper and at the execution, who saw what he reports, whom this Gospel names nowhere else, who survives the events, and whose testimony a later hand vouches for. Add that he takes from him and supplies him nothing, and that he stands in the position the Prologue gives the Son, one step down the transmission chain, rather than merely near him. Nothing in that profile is self-contradictory and its ten clauses answer to the nine conditions, the first two of them together carrying the single condition that pairs Judean standing with priestly access, whether or not any historical person answers to it. This forecloses the reading, common in the symbolic school, that the figure is an incoherence produced by layered redaction and that the

incoherence is itself the evidence of construction. A specification with no internal contradiction is a specification a person could meet.

The repair, and where the anonymity enters

The architecture is now visible. What stands is the seen event, and it stands because the Gospel spends everything on autopsy. What moves is the exposition, which begins at 1:18 with the Son setting forth the unseen Father, does not terminate at the departure, and descends one step down the transmission chain, arriving at 21:24 as a man who testifies and writes. What binds the two is position: the one in the bosom expounds, and the one in the bosom of the one in the bosom testifies. Position, not proximity, licenses the transmission, because proximity yields a report and position yields an inheritance. Gehazi at 2 Kings 5 is the proof that the distinction is real in this literature: he had all the proximity there was.

The anonymity is the condition of the position and not a decision about a man. A proper name written into the designation produces a second person, and the condition is therefore a property of how the text designates and never of whether the man had a name, since every occupant had one. The moment there are two persons, the figure stands beside the Son rather than in his position one step down the transmission chain, the *kolpos* transposition collapses into physical closeness, and the transmission degrades from inheritance to report. The anonymity and the inherited bosom are therefore not two conditions but one condition read twice, so a candidate the Gospel names elsewhere fails it however that failure is recorded, and the table records the second face only where it is separately informative, which is at the Lazarus row alone.

The comparative material sharpens this rather than merely supporting it. In the counterpart tradition the heavenly figure is not a second individual with a second name; he is the man's own image, one identity, two registers, which is what permits the angels of the Bethel targum to shuttle without confusion, and it is why Genesis 32:30 and Judges 13:18 refuse the question rather than answering it. Write a proper name into the disciple's designation and the pairing is broken, because a designation carrying a name designates a second person. A reader who knows the man's name from outside the text breaks nothing, which is why a candidate the Gospel never names elsewhere can satisfy this condition while a candidate it does name cannot.

Read this way the epithet also stops being an honour and becomes a job description. A figure identified by whose he is, rather than by who he is, is transparent by construction, which is the property a conduit requires and the property the Gospel also assigns to the Advocate, who does not speak from himself but speaks what he hears (16:13). The two figures share the transparency and differ on the temporal index, which section 9 separates.

What the reading closes on

Applied to the disciple, the counterpart structure dissolves a dilemma the literature has treated as a fork. The structural role and the historical body are not competing answers to one question. Both registers are occupied at once and neither is the real one behind the other. This re-reads 21:23 more cleanly than either school manages:

the rumour is a register collapse, taking what is true of the counterpart and predicating it of the body, and the redactor's correction is careful in exactly the way a register error requires, re-scoping the conditional without denying the abiding and without asserting the survival. The Eliyāhū inversion of section 5 is the same seam seen from the other side, the not-dying motif attaching in the older text to the one taken up and in the Johannine text to the one who remains.

The reading closes on what it claims and not on more. The exposition, the descent, the position and the anonymity compose without residue; they account for the positional loci, for the transmission at 21:24, for the household transfer at 19:27 and for the correction at 21:23; and the three components are each attested independently in the literature the Gospel inherits. They do not account for one locus the architecture does not derive, the believing on grave cloths at 20:8, which remains the strongest datum the symbolic reading holds and is not converted here into support for this one.

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The seal is scoped and the scope is part of it. It stands on the architecture of the position and on the anonymity as its condition. It does not stand on the identity of any occupant, which section 10 leaves open at the grade the evidence supports, and it does not stand on any derivation of the Fourth Gospel from any of the comparative material, which section 11 refuses explicitly.

Three falsifiers travel with it. If the *epi ton buion* reading at 1:51 were shown to be secondary, the Bethel anchor loosens and the counterpart argument drops to analogy. If 21:22-23 were shown to be a late addition with no root in the body of the Gospel, the abiding condition weakens and the co-presence argument of section 9 partially recovers its rival. And if the withheld-name refusals of Genesis 32:30 and Judges 13:18 could be shown to be a scribal or redactional artifact rather than a device, the convention argument of section 7 loses its Hebrew Bible leg and falls back on the Qumran and Qur'anic evidence alone.

9. The discriminator: two mechanically distinct functions

The designation has been read as covering one office when it covers a distinction the Gospel itself draws.

The test is the temporal index. Does the figure's operation require that the Son has already departed? If yes, the function is successive and belongs to the Advocate. If no, and the figure operates in the Son's presence, the function is co-present and belongs to the counterpart. The Gospel supplies the criterion at 16:7.

Case one, worked to the Advocate. *Sympherei hymin hina egō apeltō. Ean gar mē apeltō, ho paraklētos ou mē elthē pros hymas* (16:7). The Advocate is defined by a vacancy and cannot arrive otherwise. Add 14:17, where the world cannot receive him *because it neither sees him nor knows him*, and the second mark follows: he is constitutively unseen. Successive and non-ocular.

Case two, worked to the counterpart. The figure of 13:23 reclines against the Son at the supper. He is present before the departure, at the departure, and after it. 19:35 grounds him in seeing, which 14:17 explicitly denies the Advocate. And 15:26-27 places the two side by side in one sentence: *ekēinos martyresei peri emou; kai hymeis de martyreite*. Co-present and ocular.

Why the conflation is attractive and why it fails. The parallels are real and dense. Both are *allos*, another of the same kind at 14:16 and the other disciple at 18:15 and 20:2. Both testify, at 15:26 and 21:24. Both abide, at 14:16-17 and 21:22-23. Both are self-effacing conduits, the Advocate speaking only what he hears at 16:13. Brown set the correspondences out and did not draw the identification from them, and he was right not to. It fails at three points, each decisive alone: the temporal index at 16:7 against 13:23; the seeing at 14:17 against 19:35; and 21:23, where a community has to publicly correct a rumour about a man's death. No community issues a correction about the mortality of a personified function.

The Semitic antecedent, and what it settles. The Two Spirits treatise of the Community Rule sets a spirit of truth against a spirit of deceit under a Prince of Lights, in a dualism whose vocabulary is the closest antecedent to the Johannine *pneuma tēs alētheias*.^{24,25} The comparison has long been used to locate the Advocate's conceptual background, and it does something else here. In that treatise the spirit is a spirit, moving within men and never a man, while the Teacher who interprets is a man designated by office and never confused with it. The very library that supplies the Gospel's spirit vocabulary keeps the two categories apart, which is evidence that the distinction section 9 draws was available in the setting rather than imposed on it from outside.

What survives is the accurate statement, which is stronger than the identification it replaces. The Fourth Gospel shapes a witness in the Advocate's image, so the figure carries the Spirit's transparency and its abiding in a body that ate, ran, and could die. Prototype in the sense of template. Not cipher.

10. Discussion

The nine conditions convert the candidate question from a weighing exercise into a screening one, and the screen's power is unevenly distributed, which is stated here rather than left for a reader to compute. Counted from the table below, the eliminations run: unnamed five, seen four, co-present two, abiding two, receiver-side two, distinctness two, Judean-priestly one, outside the Twelve one, inherited bosom one, nineteen in all across fifteen rows. Two of the nine carry nine of nineteen, and three eliminate a single candidate each, one of those three being the condition already declared identical with the anonymity condition, so the distinct remainder is six conditions under seven names. Those are necessary conditions with low yield, and calling the set a screen is accurate only in that sense. Table 1 condenses the field and the fourth column states where each candidate stands, as a comment rather than a verdict.

Table 1 | The candidate slate, condensed. Rows are every candidate this study could identify in the literature it surveys, and the selection inherits that survey's sampling. Loci are Johannine unless otherwise marked.

Candidate	For	Against	Geometric fit
John son of Zebedee	Irenaeus 3.1.1; boat list 21:2; the name never appears in a Gospel where the Synoptics make him prominent	Acts 4:13 against 18:15; no call narrative in the body; never linked to Zebedee in chs. 13 to 21; Mark 10:39	Fails unnamed, Judean-priestly and non-Twelve. Best attested, worst fitted, the signature of an assigned attribution
John the Elder	Papias's double list (Eus. 3.39.4); two Ephesian tombs (3.39.6); <i>ho presbyteros</i> 2 Jn 1, 3 Jn 1; 1 Jn 1:1-3; Polycrates and the <i>petalon</i> (5.24.3)	No source ever calls him the Beloved Disciple; the two-John reading is contested; the name is inferred and never attested	Fails no condition. Its weakness is of a different kind, an inference rather than a defect, which is what a name doing no work looks like
Lazarus	The only named man the Gospel says he loved, 11:3, 11:5, 11:36; the epithet debuts at 13:23 immediately after; Bethany base; 12:10; 12:2	Named four chapters earlier; 11:5 spreads the love to Martha and Mary; 12:9-11 makes him a public spectacle; never called <i>mathētēs</i>	Fails unnamed, and therefore fails the inherited bosom with it. Second best on every other condition and fatal on that one
Thomas	Boat list 21:2; the twin epithet supplies the counterpart shape; 20:28	Named; 20:8 against 20:25 on the seeing axis; 20:24 absent when the others see	Fails unnamed and fails seen. The archetype is present in the Gospel and he is not its occupant
Mary Magdalene	19:25 at the cross; 20:1-18 primary Easter witness; 11:5	20:2 she runs to him; masculine participates at 21:20-24; requires a redaction with no manuscript support	Fails unnamed and fails distinctness at 20:2. Recovers a real historical question and not this identification
John Mark	Acts 12:12 a Jerusalem house; Col 4:10 a Levitical family; not of the Twelve; Mark 14:51-52	No ancient tradition attaches him to this Gospel; Acts 13:13 abandonment against the abiding; already carries the Second Gospel	Satisfies unnamed, since this Gospel never names him, and fails abiding at Acts 13:13. Jerusalem standing is the second condition he supplies
Matthias	Acts 1:21-22 requires a witness from the baptism onward, matching 1:35-40; outside the Twelve during the narrative	No textual hook of any kind	Satisfies unnamed, since this Gospel never names him, and fails on the absence of any hook. Inference from a job description rather than from the text
Nathanael	Boat list 21:2; receives the Bethel saying at 1:47-51; called a true Israelite	Named at 1:45 and 21:2; 1:51 predicates of the Son of Man and not of him; no love language	Fails unnamed. Stands nearest the counterpart text and is not its subject
The youth of Mark 10:21	<i>ēgapēsen auton</i> ; Mark 14:51-52; wealth would explain 19:27 and 18:15	Mark 10:22 he goes away grieved, the inverse of abiding; the Mar Saba letter is unresolved and can bear no weight	Fails abiding at the one verse that supplies him. No Johannine hook
Paul	Non-Twelve; a standing rival to Peter; 2 Cor 12:2-4	Gal 1:11-12 and 2 Cor 5:16 renounce exactly what 19:35 requires; dead c. 62-64; no Pauline vocabulary in the Gospel	Fails seen at the root, by his own explicit refusal of it. The clearest failure on the slate
Apollos	Acts 18:24 Alexandrian and mighty in the scriptures, suiting the Prologue; Ephesus	Acts 18:25 knew only John's baptism, so no autopsy; no attestation	Fails seen. A profile match to the Prologue is not a match to the position
Benjamin, typological	Deut 33:12 LXX beloved of the Lord, dwelling between his shoulders; Gen 35:18 born at the mother's death	No Johannine signal; requires an unnamed tribal typology	Fails co-presence and receiver-side. The figure eats at 21:12 and runs at 20:4
The Paraclete personified	<i>allos</i> 14:16 and 18:15; testify 15:26 and 21:24; abide 14:16 and 21:23; 16:13	16:7 successive against 13:23 co-present; 14:17 unseen against 19:35; 15:26-27 sets them side by side; 21:23	Fails co-presence, seen, receiver-side and distinctness. Template and not cipher, per section 9
Ideal disciple, construct	13:23 paradigmatic; 19:26-27 constitutes a family; 20:8 believes without an appearance; anonymity fits a type	21:23 and its careful correction; 19:35 and 21:24; 18:15 gratuitous social fact; 20:4 yields no symbolism	Satisfies unnamed and fails seen and distinctness. Weakened further by the Teacher of Righteousness, where functional designation and historicity coexist
Composite or school figure	21:24 <i>we know</i> ; 1 Jn 1:1-3 plural voice; accounts for residue and idealisation together	21:23 concerns one man's death; singular participates; a school does not recline at a supper	Satisfies distinctness and fails co-presence. Correct about the final hand, wrong about the figure, and the Bārūkh arrangement shows the two are ordinarily distinct

Three results follow from the slate, and only the third is new.

The requirement set is satisfiable, so the vacancy is a specification and not a paradox. Every candidate the Gospel itself names elsewhere fails at the same condition: five of the fifteen rows fail there, and they are precisely the five the Gospel names in another scene, Zebedee's sons at 21:2, Lazarus, Thomas, the Magdalene and Nathanael. That converts seven apparently independent objections into one structural fact,

since a name in the designation converts the counterpart into a second person and the unnamed condition and the inherited-bosom condition fall together. The remaining failures are not instances of it and are not claimed as such. And John the Elder is the only row with no failure, with a weakness different in kind from the others: it fails no condition and rests on an inference rather than an attestation, which is a weaker floor than a satisfied condition and a stronger one than a

manufactured exception. It is also what a name that did almost no work would look like from this distance. The paper does not seal on it and does not need to, since the architecture stands whether the position was filled by the Elder, by an unrecoverable Judean disciple, or by someone the record has lost.

The cross-corpus controls

Table 2 sets the antecedents and the controls beside the Johannine figure. Its final row is the target and not a control, set there for reading against the eleven above it and never counted among them. Its fifth column is the operative one, because a parallel earns its place by what it separates, and at the final row that column states the thesis rather than a discrimination, which is what a target row does.

Table 2 | Antecedents and controls. The fifth column carries the discrimination, not the resemblance.

Figure and locus	How designated	Ground of transmission	Abiding	What it separates
Yehoshu'a, Ex 24:13; 33:11; Num 27:18-20	<i>mesbaret</i> , <i>na'ar</i> , and by name	Laying on of hands, transfer of <i>bod</i>	Does not depart from the tent	Named throughout, and the transfer is a public rite rather than a position
Elisha, 1 Kgs 19:21; 2 Kgs 2:9-12	<i>mesbaret</i> , and by name	Sight, stated as the condition at 2:10	Follows to the last station	Supplies the seeing condition exactly; the master is the one who does not die, and whether the pair stands in two positions is not settled here
Bärükh, Jer 36:4, 18; 45	By name and patronym	Dictation, <i>'al pi Yirmiyābū</i>	Not at issue	Supplies the writing hand distinct from the voice, and shows how a name later collects a library
Gehazi, 2 Kgs 5:20-27	<i>na'ar</i> , and by name	Forfeited	Present but disqualified	The negative control: proximity alone confers nothing
The wrestler, Gen 32:29-30	Refuses the question	Blessing and a new name for the asker	Departs at daybreak	Withholding is marked and performed, and it attaches to the two-register figure
The messenger, Judg 13:17-18	Refuses, ground given: <i>pe'li'y</i>	Announcement	Ascends in the flame	The refusal is reasoned, so the withheld name is a device and not a gap
Raphael, Tob 5:13; 12:15	Withheld as Azariah, then disclosed	Accompaniment	Whole narrative	The convention's other branch: disclosure is the normal resolution, and John declines it
Enoch, 1 En 71:14	By name; the counterpart unnamed until disclosed	Vision, then identification	Not at issue	One identity in two registers, stated outright, with the man unaware of it
Teacher of Righteousness, CD 1:11; 1QpHab 7:4-5	<i>moreh ha-tsedeg</i> , never a personal name	Mysteries made known to him	Founding and continuing	The closest formal analogue: functional designation and historicity coexist without strain
The servant, Q 18:65	<i>'abdan min 'ibādīnā</i>	Knowledge from the divine presence	Companionship dissolved at 18:78	Abiding fails, and the text closes with a full explanation rather than a residue
The second of two, Q 9:40	<i>thāniya thmayni, sāḥibibi</i>	Not a transmission scene	In the cave	Designation purely by position in a pair, with no vacancy created
The Beloved Disciple	<i>hon ēgapa</i> , never a name	Sight, 19:35; position, 13:23	21:22-23, left conditional	Assembles all four components and closes on an unresolved conditional, which is what leaves a vacancy

The controls do three things, and a fourth result at section 7 is comparative and is not among them, so this list is what the controls establish and not the whole of what the comparison yields. They establish that the seeing condition, the staged transmission, the two-register counterpart and the withheld name were each available and attested, which is the component set of section 6 and no other, so the Johannine figure is an assembly of known parts and not an invention requiring a special hypothesis. They establish, through the Teacher of Righteousness, that functional designation and historicity coexist without strain, which removes the assumption that anonymity is evidence of fictionality. And through Tobit and Q 18:78 they establish what the Fourth Gospel does not do: it does not disclose and it does not explain, and the vacancy is what is left when a text declines both.

The falsifier

A stable early tradition of a *named* Beloved Disciple, independent of Irenaeus and not downstream of the anti-gnostic pressure, would convert the vacancy from designed to suppressed and invert the argument. No such tradition is known, and the reading therefore stands on an absence, which is a weaker floor than a presence and is typed as such here rather than in a footnote. That falsifier is also unavailable to any present party, since it waits on a discovery no argument can produce, and a test nobody can run is a poor sole test. The reading carries a second falsifier that is available now and can be executed against any corpus by any party willing to adjudicate the fourth property, for which this study supplies criteria and not a decision procedure: exhibit a text that grounds the warrant of its narrated past in a witness's sight, stages a transmission to him, designates him by position, stands him in two positions at once, and

names him. One such text refutes the sufficiency claim of section 6 without waiting on any discovery.

11. Fences

Five inflations the reading will not carry, each refused by a locus or a mechanism. The comparative scope of this study makes the last three load-bearing rather than formal.

The figure is not the Advocate. Refused by 16:7, by 14:17 against 19:35, and by 21:23. The template relation is real and stated in section 9; the identification is not available, and every reading that has reached for it has had to discount one of those three.

The counterpart is not a divine hypostasis. The Bethel and angelic material licenses simultaneity in two registers for a man and licenses nothing above it. Nothing here predicates of the disciple what the Gospel predicates of the Son, and nothing makes the counterpart an object of veneration or a member of any divine order. The texts of section 6 are careful in exactly this way: Exodus 23:21 grounds the angel's authority in a Name that is *within* him and not his own, and the targumic tradition has the angels behold an image rather than worship a second power. The reading is refused if taken otherwise.

The anonymity is not a puzzle awaiting solution. Refused by the argument of section 8 and, in the comparative field, by Q 18:22, which names reconstruction of a withheld identifier as guessing at the unseen. If the anonymity is a condition of the position, solving it is a category error rather than a discovery.

The structural claim does not settle the historical one. Refused by the scope of the seal. That the position is required tells us nothing about whether a body filled it, and the counterpart structure means the two are not rivals. Any use of this paper to argue that the figure was therefore fictional, or therefore historical, exceeds what is closed here.

Nothing here derives any text from any other. Refused by chronology in one direction and by method in the other. The Hebrew Bible antecedents are the literature the Fourth Gospel is written out of and the relation is inheritance rather than proof. The Qumran and pseudepigraphic material is setting rather than source, and its own attributions are contested where this paper says they are. The twin literature receives the Fourth Gospel and does not precede it. The Qur'anic material is an independent treatment of a shared problem, it is load-bearing on no step above, and the comparison decides nothing about the standing of any text involved. Above all, the shared structures identified in sections 5 through 7 are carried by four

unrelated vocabularies, which is why they cannot be and are not explained by borrowing in any direction.

12. Scope

The domain guard, and the confusion is a live one rather than a manufactured neighbour.

The Beloved Disciple is routinely conflated with the author of the Fourth Gospel, and the Gospel's own last sentence separates them. 21:24 says that this disciple testifies to these things and wrote them, and adds *and we know that his testimony is true*. Whatever *egrapsen* covers, whether composition, dictation, or the standing behind a school's work, the plural that follows is not the singular that precedes it. There is a testifying figure and there is a finishing hand. Jeremiah 36 shows the arrangement was ordinary and 4 Ezra 14:42-44, with its five men writing at dictation, shows it was still ordinary in this period.

The confusion drives the whole authorship debate in one direction. Ask who wrote the Fourth Gospel and every answer must be someone capable of this Greek and this theology. Ask who the Beloved Disciple was and the requirement set is the one in section 8, which says nothing about Greek style. The two questions have different answers in principle and possibly in fact, and the traditional attribution's chief rhetorical advantage is that it answers both at once with one name, which is a convenience and not an argument.

A second and smaller confusion is worth naming. The English *beloved* invites reading the epithet as a statement about the intensity of an affection and hence as an honour conferred, with the discomfort about favouritism that has followed it through the devotional literature. The Greek is a relative clause and functions as a designation. Section 3 shows the verbs will not carry a graded scale of affection, and the comparative field shows the formation is one of several ways this literature designates a man by his relation rather than by his person, alongside *mesharet*, *moreh ha-tsedek*, *'abdan min 'ibādīnā* and *thāniya thnayni*. What is being said is where the man stands.

Appendix. The epithet and its adjacent designations

Every occurrence of the epithet, with the Greek at issue and the immediate setting. Translations are the author's, made from the Greek and kept short; they are working renderings for reference and not a contribution of this study.

Table A1 The epithet, five occurrences, all in John.				
Reference	Rendering	Greek	Setting	Note
John 13:23	One of his disciples was reclining in the bosom of Jesus, the one whom Jesus loved.	<i>en tō kolpō tou Iēsou, hon ēgapa</i>	Last supper, just after the betrayal is announced at 13:21-22. Peter signals to him to ask who; at 13:25 he leans back on the chest and asks.	First occurrence. <i>Kolpos</i> appears here and at 1:18 only. A channel scene: Peter cannot ask and routes through him.
John 19:26	Jesus therefore, seeing his mother and the disciple whom he loved standing by, says to his mother: Woman, behold your son.	<i>ton mathētēn parestōta hon ēgapa</i>	At the cross. 19:27 gives the reverse, behold your mother, and from that hour the disciple took her <i>eis ta idia</i> .	Present where the others are absent. Acquires a household obligation, which presupposes a household.
John 20:2	So she runs and comes to Simon Peter and to the other disciple, the one whom Jesus loved.	<i>ton allon mathētēn hon ephilei</i>	Mary Magdalene at the empty tomb before dawn; she reports the body taken.	The only <i>phileō</i> , and the only explicit equation of the epithet with the other disciple. She runs to him, so the text distinguishes them.
John 21:7	That disciple therefore, whom Jesus loved, says to Peter: it is the Lord.	<i>ho mathētēs ekeinos hon ēgapa</i>	The catch at the Sea of Tiberias. Peter then girds himself and throws himself into the water.	Recognition precedes Peter's action, as at 20:8. He tells and Peter acts.
John 21:20	Peter, turning, sees the disciple whom Jesus loved following, the one who also leaned back on his chest at the supper and said: Lord, who is the one betraying you?	<i>hon ēgapa ... anepesen ... epi to stēthos</i>	After Peter's restoration and the prediction of his death. Peter asks at 21:21 what will become of this one.	Explicit back-reference to 13:25, using <i>stēthos</i> and not <i>kolpos</i> . Sets up the conditional at 21:22.

The four passages below carry no epithet. Identifying them with the figure above is an inference, near-universal in the literature and nowhere stated by the text, and section 4 treats each on its own terms.

Table A2 Adjacent designations, no epithet.				
Reference	Rendering	Greek	Setting	Status
John 1:37-40	The two disciples heard him speak and followed Jesus. One of the two was Andrew, Simon Peter's brother.	<i>beis ek tōn duo</i>	Disciples of the Baptist; the abiding question <i>pou meneis</i> and the answer that they abode with him that day.	One named, one never named. Inference only, and the inclusio argument rests on it.
John 18:15-16	Simon Peter followed Jesus, and another disciple. That disciple was known to the high priest and went in with Jesus into the courtyard, and spoke to the doorkeeper and brought Peter in.	<i>allos mathētēs ... gnōstos tō archierei</i>	The arrest and the courtyard, immediately before Peter's first denial.	A gratuitous social fact. Priestly-household standing, the hardest of the nine conditions for any candidate.
John 19:35	And the one who has seen has testified, and his testimony is true, and he knows that he speaks truly, so that you also may believe.	<i>ho beōrakōs memartyrēken</i>	Immediately after the spear thrust and the blood and water.	Grounds the Gospel's whole warrant in sight, and does not name the seer.
John 21:24	This is the disciple who testifies to these things and who wrote these things, and we know that his testimony is true.	<i>ho martyrōn ... kai grapsas ... oidamen</i>	The Gospel's penultimate sentence.	Splits the voices. He testified and wrote, we vouch, and the testifying figure and the finishing hand are not the same.

Two facts govern any reading of the tables above and are established at section 3. The alternation of *agapāō* and *phileō* carries no graded affection: the Father loves the Son with the first at 3:35 and the second at 5:20, and Lazarus takes both at 11:3, 11:5 and 11:36. And the adjectival *agapētos*, which carries the title in the Synoptics, is applied to Jesus nowhere in this Gospel, which uses *monogenēs* instead, so the participial love-clause is free and lands on a disciple.

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Method

The requirement analysis is built from inside the Fourth Gospel alone, and the comparative frame is opened deliberately, with the change of genre and the three rules that discipline it declared in section 1. The argument's core remains checkable against the Greek text without recourse to any secondary work; the comparative sections add antecedents and controls and do not add premises to the structural argument, which stands on the Johannine loci alone.

Verification

Citations give author, title and year. Where an imprint, page range or edition could not be verified against a clean edition in this pass, the detail has been omitted rather than supplied, and no page reference is asserted anywhere in this paper. Scrolls are cited by siglum and column. Four items are marked in the body as disputed rather than resolved: the two-John reading of Papias; the *eis* against *en* construction at 1:18 and 13:23; the integration of 1 Enoch 71 with the rest of the Similitudes; and the identity of the speaker in the Self-Glorification Hymn. The targumim and Genesis Rabbah are redacted later than the Fourth Gospel, and the first-century currency of the counterpart doctrine is carried by the Prayer of Joseph, Matthew 18:10 and Acts 12:15 rather than by the rabbinic material; the argument is scoped accordingly. The Peshitta reading at 1:18 and 13:23 is reported as a reception datum and carries no weight in the argument.

Competing interests

The author declares none. No text is derived from any other in either direction at any point in this paper, and the shared structures identified are carried by four unrelated vocabularies, which is stated in section 3 as the reason borrowing cannot explain them.

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